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Shifting politics in Bedouin love poetry

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Document Type: Essay

Original Page: 32

Culture (OWC): [Libyan Bedouin \(MT09\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1978-1987

Coverage Date: 1950-1987

Place Coverage: Western Desert, Egypt

Section Title(S)

2. Shifting politics in Bedouin love poetry

This avoidance is said to be motivated by a sentiment, called *hasham*, which can be translated as “modesty,” “embarrassment,” or “shame.” *Hasham* refers both to what we might think of as an internal state of shyness, embarrassment, or shame and to a set of behaviors associated with these “feelings,” although the Awlad ‘Ali do not make that distinction. The cultural repertoire of such behaviors includes dressing modestly for both sexes (which means covering the hair, arms to the wrists, and legs to the ankles) and aspects of demeanor such as downcast eyes, formal posture, and refraining from eating, smoking, talking, laughing, and joking. It is also marked, for married women, by veiling in certain circumstances. Very importantly, as I have described, it involves sexual propriety. What is clear is the *hasham* is the moral sentiment. The person with social sense, the good person — *tahashshams* — feels shy and acts modestly in the appropriate situations. Children, idiots, and the insane don’t. Nor do bad people.

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The question that comes up at this point is what one should make of this disjunction between the two sorts of sentiments Bedouins express about “love.” As I have argued elsewhere (1986), several obvious types of explanation do not seem satisfactory. The first, that people are being hypocritical or engaging in acts of self-presentation, underestimates the commitment to morality among the Awlad ‘Ali, attributing to them EuroAmerican ideological notions about the opposition between individual freedom and social restraint. A weaker version of this argument, but one no less steeped in our cultural assumptions, is that we are dealing with moral (i.e., social) constraint versus personal expression. Related to these interpretations is the safety-valve argument that sees the poetry as providing

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release from the pressures of moral conformity, a theory that has the added drawback of conceiving of society as a machine. All of these theories about the contradictions between the two discourses on sentiment 33 privilege the poetic sentiments as in some sense the truer ones. Is this because, as Foucault (1985:5) has argued and the radio therapist demonstrated, in the modern West we have come to search for the truth of our being in desire, or more broadly, in feelings?

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